Infinity

By Sarah Dessen

INTRODUCTION

Are you good at making decisions? Are you able to make them in a timely fashion? And are the outcomes you get what they should be? What is the process you use to make a decision? Is a decision based on your gut feeling? Or perhaps what your heart tells you? Or in those few rare cases – even what the head tells you?

We all make many decisions every day. Some are quite trivial, while others can change the direction of our lives. But the bottom line is . . . as long as the decision is your own, it doesn't matter how long it takes you to make it. In Infinity by Sarah Dessen, a young girl ponders her ability to make her own choices. Infinity by Sarah Dessen.

Lately I don't dream about Anthony. I dream about the rotary.

Most people don't even know what rotaries are. That's because most towns have those most modern of inventions, stoplights, to deal with traffic. Not here. Instead, some genius decided however many years ago to put in this big circle, with all the main roads feeding into

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it, then sat back to watch people crash to their deaths as they attempted to negotiate it.

My first experience with the rotary was when I was about seven. "Oh my God," my mother said, poking her glasses up the bridge of her nose, which she always does when she's really nervous. "What is this?" The answer came in the form of a loud, impatient beep from behind us.

"I'm merging!" she shrieked. And we were merging, pretty well, slowly easing into traffic. In fact, we were almost relaxed when we had to try to get back out; no easy trick, as there were many cars merging in. We got stuck on the inside track for two more turns, watching our exit go by, before my mother panicked and just sort of jerked the wheel, sending us in its general direction. And that was when the station wagon hit us.

The entire episode ended with a ticket, our insurance rates rising, and my mother swearing to never do the rotary ever again, which seemed

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somewhat overdramatic, until we realized that she meant it.

My boyfriend, Anthony, is a year older than me. He's good at the rotary, but he understands my hesitation. In fact, since I got my [learner's] permit, we've spent a lot of time going in circles together, practicing. We started late at night, when it was pretty much deserted . . .

"Okay, now the first thing you're gonna do is stop and look to the left here Okay now," Anthony said. "Just ease out."

I did. Just as my mother had, all those years earlier. But this time there was no one coming; it was dark. No problem. But still my heart was beating hard, thumping against my chest, even as I picked up speed.

"See?" Anthony said. "Piece of cake, right?"

"Right," I said. We passed all the exits once, then started through again. Of course this was okay, I thought. Like a merry-go-round, only faster. But it was a trial run. And trial runs are always easier.

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Finally Anthony pointed toward the beach route exit. I slowed down, pulling up into a space right behind the lifeguard stand. Then I cut the engine. "You did good tonight," Anthony said. And then he leaned over and kissed me. I knew he would. I knew because we'd been practicing this, too, all this time, trial run after trial run. As with the rotary, what came next was obvious. And scary. And, it seemed, inevitable.

I'd been with Anthony for more than six months. He wanted to sleep with me. He hadn't come out and said it, but he didn't really have to. Us having sex would be a natural progression: Like moving from learner's permit to license, there's only one thing left. And so I have this choice. To either merge in or take the long way home.

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"I'm so proud of you!" That was my mother when I came out of the DMV office, holding my new license. "You know, you don't have to do the rotary right away."

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"I know," I said. We'd already discussed this during the weeks I'd had my permit, when she'd officially taught me all of her extended shortcuts. "But I think I should just go ahead and get it over with."

My mother had gotten accustomed to taking the long way everywhere: It wasn't even a burden for her anymore. That's the thing about habits. And fears. At first they might seem like trouble, but eventually they just fold in, becoming part of the fabric. I longed for the simple, solid logic of traffic lights, no decisions necessary: Green means go, red means stop, yellow means slow down or run the light-make up your mind, though, because time's a-wasting.

I could do this. It wasn't any different from all those nights I'd merged and circled the rotary with Anthony: The traffic was just a little heavier. I told myself I wasn't just doing this for me, but for my mother as well. The traffic was picking up now, the last intersection coming up in front of us. The engine seemed to grind as I downshifted, the other drivers pressing in around me.

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There was a honk a few cars back-not at us, but loud nonetheless-and I have to admit it threw me, sending a quick hot flush up the back of my neck. It didn't help, of course, that my mother gasped in a breath loud enough for me to hear over the wind whistling through my not-quite-shut window. And just like that, I lost my confidence, my hand reaching up to hit the right tum signal as if it had made the choice all by itself.

"It's okay," she said as we breezed past a few neighborhoods, with only two left turns, one access road, and a shopping center parking lot to traverse before arriving home. "You'll do it when you're ready." But I was angry with myself for ducking out. It seemed a bad way to begin things, with a false start, a last-minute abort so close to takeoff. As if I'd come this far, right to the brink, and in pulling back set a precedent that would echo, like the sound of my mother's gasp, next time.

I avoided the rotary for a week and a half. There were several almosts, most of them with

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Anthony in the car, pep-talking me like a motivational coach. "Be the road!" he urged me as we coasted up to the ROTARY AHEAD signs. But always, I took that last possible right turn, while Anthony would just shake his head, easing an elbow out the window, and say nothing.

His urging was gentler, but no less insistent, when the car was off and we were alone together at the beach. "I love you, I love you," he'd whisper, and I'd feel that same hot flush, traveling up from my feet, the adrenaline rush that was a mix of fear and longing. We'd gotten very close, but again, I pulled back. Scared. It seemed ludicrous that I was unable to follow through with anything, as if from sixteen on I was doomed to be ruled by indecision.

"I just don't understand why you don't want to," he asked me one night as we sat looking at the water. There was no gray here, no compromise. We'd come up so quickly on all or nothing that it blind-sided me, a mere glint out of the comer of my eye before full impact.

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"I want it to be right," I told him.

"How can this not be right?" He sat up straighter, jutting a finger up at the windshield. "Moonlight? Check. Crashing waves? Check. I love you? Check. You love me? ... "

It took me a second, just a second, to realize it was my tum to say something. "Check," I said quickly, but he glared at me and let his finger drop, as if this explained everything.

As the days passed, and I found myself consistently taking the long way everywhere, I got frustrated with all these decisions. A part of me wanted to barrel into the rotary blindfolded, pushing the gas pedal hard, and let whatever was going to happen just happen, anything for it to be over. The same part sometimes was so close to giving into Anthony's pleadings, wanting to finally just relax against the seat and let him do what he wanted, just give it all up and finally ease myself of these burdens.

Scenario number one, of course, was stupid: I'd cause a multicar pileup and kill myself. As far as

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number two, well, it was harder to say. What would change? Maybe there wouldn't be visible damage, dented bumpers or crumpled hoods. But something in me would be different, even if no one else could tell. Like a car that's been wrecked and fixed, but the frame stays bent. Just because you don't see it doesn't mean something isn't there. Or gone.

The fall carnival appeared in one afternoon, with rides and a midway and the huge Ferris wheel. I used my money to buy a funnel cake and tickets for [for Anthony and me].

Behind us was a guy with his daughter, who looked to be about eight. She had a big stuffed lion under her arm and was gripping her dad's hand, staring up at the Ferris wheel as it moved lazily above us.

"Now, honey," the man said, squatting down beside her, "you don't have to go on it if you don't want to. Because it might be scary."

"I want to," she said. I watched her face, the careful way she studied the ride as it came to a stop,

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I envied her for knowing exactly what she wanted. But it was easy when you're little, I figured. Not so many choices.

[Then] we were at the very top. Anthony was pressing against me, hardly caring that this was not the place, not the time. All those nights at the beach, when I'd pushed him away, I hadn't known exactly why, just that it hadn't felt right. But as my view from high up narrowed, I realized that my relationship with Anthony had done the same, going from a wide endless horizon of possibilities to one pinpoint of a destination. I wanted to have choices, to know that I could, at any moment, still take the long way home. Sure, there was a quick way to anywhere. But sometimes, when you took the shortcut, you missed the view.

"I love you," he whispered in my ear. "I want you." But it wasn't enough. As I pushed him away, I knew that [the "right"] time would never come. Anthony was tired of losing at this game. If he couldn't have me, he'd find an easier prize. The ride

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hadn't even come to a full stop when he pushed the safety bar away from us. Then he stomped down the stairs, pushing past all the people lined up for the next ride while I climbed out slowly, taking my time, telling myself to pay attention to how the earth felt beneath me and not take it for granted anymore.

I'd driven, and Anthony was gone, lost in the crowd. Even though I'd only been driving for a couple of weeks, it already felt more natural. Maybe all it took, in the end, was the time to let the new soak in. To stand in the face of change and size it up, acquaint yourself, before jumping in. It was all the pressure that was so hard, those little nudges forward, poke poke poke. If you just backed off and let it come to you, it would.

When I finally made it to the light, I hit my blinker, signaling the left tum that would lead me around the shopping mall and through two neighborhoods before depositing me onto my own road. It was the way I'd always gone, up until now, but this time I didn't feel that burning burst of shame in

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it, knowing I was taking the easy way out. I just remembered the view from up high, the way all the roads led to one another eventually. It didn't matter which route you took, as long as you got home.

There was that burst of freedom in realizing that my choice was okay. But even so, at the last minute, I turned my wheel to the right, surprising even myself, and shifted into second as the rotary came up into my sight. This was normally the moment I was dumb scared, hands shaking, but this time I only moved closer, pressing my shoulders back against the seat as if taking the scariest and most exhilarating of rides. I glanced in my rearview [mirror] and saw the Ferris wheel. Another circle, representing a kind of infinity that I was only beginning to understand. I turned the wheel, leaning into the first curve, feeling that rush of accomplishment and speed. It was happening so fast, but I was there, right there, alive, wanting this moment to be like brass rings and Ferris wheels and all the circulars of this life and others, never ending.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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